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Green FoMO: The Psychological Influence of Fear of Missing Out on Sustainable Consumer Behavior, Green-Energy Adoption and Energy Conservation among Gen Z

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14 **Research Topic:** Analyzing the influence of Fear of Missing Out on Gen Z's sustainable consumer behavior

Title: Green FoMO: The Psychological Influence of Fear of Missing Out on Sustainable Consumer Behavior, Green-Energy Adoption and Energy Conservation among Gen Z

Abstract

The escalating environmental awareness of the global climate change has encouraged individuals to adopt more sustainable lifestyles. Primarily through social media interactions, digital green behavior has significantly become visible. This leads to individuals comparing their own ecological participation with others, creating a phenomenon referred to in this proposal as 'Green Fear of Missing Out'. The purpose of the study aims to examine the influence of Fear of Missing Out on Gen Z's eco-friendly purchasing and to present it as a social-psychological factor in motivating consumer to maintain a sustainable behavior, some of which has been remained unexplored. This study will employ mixed-methods analysis, including surveys and semi-structured interviews.

Introduction

With emerging digital technologies, the usage of social media has increased. Social media is a platform where internet-users share contents and mainly interact with one another through numerous applications [1]. Ever since its birth, social network sites (SNSs) have been incorporated into individuals' daily routines [1]. These sites have been invented with slightly different purposes, intended for different audience with various interests and mindsets. In 2025, 68.7% of the world's population uses social media, which amounts to 5.66 billion [2]. This creation makes daily communication become interconnected, making the experience easier for people to stay updated on the digital social activities. Thus, the spread of data information accelerates. Such social media platforms provide users quick access to information in everyday life, allowing them to witness the diverse events happening across the globe. With this privilege, many are prone to social comparison [3].

Social media does not only show users what other individuals are doing at a current time, but also influence perceptions of the desirable environmentally-friendly behaviors [4]. Generation Z, better known as 'digital natives' [5] have a reputation of being chronically online by spending their lifetime living in a connected world. They normally process information differently and have rapid data absorption as they are competent in using the online communication tools. With these characteristics, the algorithm featuring sustainable lifestyles become more visible to their eyes. Such examples include the 3 Rs (Recycling, Reducing, Reusing), adopting green products and living low-carbon lifestyles. This intrigues their psychological phenomenon, widely popular as 'FoMO'. The term is defined as a persistent concern and fear of being excluded from experiences that other participants find worthwhile and rewarding [3]. Moreover, a similar mechanism occurs when non-participants observe others engaging in environmentally responsible behaviors.

Green Fear of Missing Out (FoMO) is the anxiety consumers feel when they witness other individuals adopting eco-friendly lifestyle and conserving energy, contributing to sustainability in vital roles, without their participation. This is a combination of the co-existing psychological concept Fear of Missing Out (FoMO) with environmentalism, which plays a pivotal role in

influencing consumer buying behavior. This deeply encourages Gen Z to take part in ways to help conserve the environment. According to 'Journal of Environmental Psychology', a study proposed in 2025 about the relationship between comparison and green behavior [6], increased social comparison can stimulate green intentions, supporting the idea of converting online actions into offline behaviors along with enhanced pro-environmental actions.

Research Question

- To what extent does exposure to others' sustainable responsibilities on social media relate to Green FoMO?
- How is Green FoMO associated with the adoption of sustainable consumer behavior and eco-friendly green behaviors among Gen Z?
- What factors contribute to Gen Z experiencing Green FoMO when exposed to influencers' sustainable lifestyles and behaviors on social media?

Literature Review

Previous Research

8 FoMO is a psychological phenomenon, which is characterized by the desire to remain continually connected and aware of what others are doing [3]. This concept was first established in 2013 as a psychological construct by A. K. Przybylski et al [3]. Recent study has shown that social media increases exposure to others' lifestyles and activities. Therefore, numbers of social comparison and the likelihood of experiencing FoMO increase. Another research has proven that social comparison helps influence users' green intentions [6]. A particular study has presented relationships between online information and Gen Z's green purchase intentions [7]. These findings suggest the basis of Green FoMO.

Research Gaps

Although, numerous studies have been focused on FoMO, they focus more on social media and interactions, hence missing the detail of connecting environmental behavior with it, whereas existing environmental studies have paid more attention into environmental awareness and sustainable behaviors. These areas have been studied separately by majority of the authors. Although social media has been linked to Gen Z's green behavior [7], research is still limited on how observing sustainability can create a sense of missing out and to what extent the influence on eco-friendly behavior can achieve. Thus, this paper will address this gap by employing mixed-methods approach.

Proposed Methodology

This study will include the usage of mixed-methods approach.

Quantitative Research:

An online survey will be provided to Gen Z individuals (people born between 1997 and 2012) who encompass different levels of education according to their age, including lower secondary to 13 colleges and universities. The survey will primarily employ a 5-point Likert scale. Questions will

be designed with the purpose of measuring participants' exposure to sustainable behaviors on social media, their level of Green FoMO and their eco-friendly purchasing behaviors. Sampling method will be used to select Gen Z with varied engagement with the subject, *(n=250)*.

Qualitative Research:

Semi-structured interviews will be conducted to the selected Gen Z participants with different levels of Green FoMO, *(n=40)* with the aim of conducting four per day. The selected participants must be born between 1997 and 2012, there are no further age restrictions. In these private questioning sessions, the study can comprehend participants' genuine feelings toward the green observations they made online, whether they experience exclusion or rather motivation from the exposure, their call-for-actions, and such preventions disabling them to fully activate their potential. This will fill in the gap of how sustainability breeds FoMO and drives eco-friendly actions.

Data Analysis:

- *Independent Variables (IVs)*: Green FoMO: To what extent do Gen Z feels they are missing out
- *Dependent Variables (DVs)*: Sustainable Green Behavior: To what extent do Gen Z engage in eco-friendly behavior
- *Quantitative and Qualitative Analysis*: Data will be analyzed using descriptive statistics and association analysis. Interviewees' response will be analyzed using thematic analysis.

Ethical Consideration:

Only voluntary participants will be selected for semi-structured interviews and anonymity will remain for all participants.

Possible Limitations:

Participants might exaggerate or understate their green behavior. Younger age within the sample group might not grasp the direction of the questions well.

Conclusion

12 Previous studies have focused on Fear of Missing Out and its association with social media. Topics about social comparison is proven to influence green intentions and sustainable consumption among Gen Z. This proposal is expected to help examine whether observing others' 15 sustainable lifestyles can contribute to Green Fear of Missing Out and its association with environmentally friendly behavior.

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